

Lesson 17: “What Shall I Do That I May Inherit Eternal Life?”

Purpose: To help us become willing to sacrifice things of the world to inherit the kingdom of heaven.

1. Trusting in riches can keep a person out of the kingdom of God.

- Mark 10:17-30 The rich young man, “there came one running, and kneeled to him”

**Why do you think the Lord asked him to give up all his possessions?
What is the difference between possessing riches and trusting in them?
How does the Savior’s instruction to the rich man apply to us?**

- Mark 12:41-44 The widow’s mite

**What was the widow willing to do that the rich young man was not?
How can we develop an attitude like the poor widow’s?**

→ 1. Elder Bruce R. McConkie

→ 2. Lectures on Faith

→ 3. Elder Dallin H. Oaks

→ 4. President Joseph F. Smith

2. Seek heavenly, rather than earthly, treasures.

- Luke 12:13-21 “speak unto my brother, that he divide the inheritance with me”

**What is covetousness? What is envy?
What things do we covet or envy today?
How do coveting and envying change us?**

Parable of the rich fool

→ 5. Elder Neal A. Maxwell

**What might he have done with his abundance if he had been seeking heavenly treasures?
How can we determine whether we are too concerned with material possessions?
How can we be more generous with our wealth and other blessings, such as time and talents?**

3. Followers of Christ must be willing to forsake all to be true disciples.

- Luke 14:15-33 Parable of the great supper

→ 6. Elder James E. Talmage

→ 7. President J. Reuben Clark

**What excuses do we make for not feasting at the Lord’s Table?
What are some things disciples today are asked to sacrifice?
What has the Lord asked you to sacrifice?
How have you been blessed for making these sacrifices?**

4. Seek spiritual wealth with enthusiasm and energy.

- Luke 16:1-12 The unjust steward

→ 8. Elder James E. Talmage

→ 9. Elder James E. Talmage

“The Lord was not suggesting that we should emulate the evil practices of the unjust servant, but that we should seek spiritual wealth with the same eagerness and effort that the servant displayed in seeking material wealth.” (*Lesson Manual*, 71-72)

“Silently compare the amount of time, thought, and energy [you] devote to accumulating money and possessions with the amount of time, thought, and energy [you] devote to seeking spiritual treasures.” (*Lesson Manual*, 72)

How can we become more dedicated and enthusiastic in seeking spiritual feasts and treasures?

(*The Life and Teachings of Jesus and His Apostles: Course Manual (Religion 211-212).*)

Next Week: New Testament Lesson 18: “He Was Lost, and Is Found” Luke 15; 17

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➡ 1. **Elder Bruce R. McConkie:** “It is written: ‘He who is not able to abide the law of a celestial kingdom cannot abide a celestial glory.’ ([D&C 88:22](#).) The law of sacrifice is a celestial law; so also is the law of consecration. Thus to gain that celestial reward which we so devoutly desire, we must be able to live these two laws.

“Sacrifice and consecration are inseparably intertwined. The law of consecration is that we consecrate our time, our talents, and our money and property to the cause of the Church: such are to be available to the extent they are needed to further the Lord’s interests on earth.

“The law of sacrifice is that we are willing to sacrifice all that we have for the truth’s sake—our character and reputation; our honor and applause; our good name among men; our houses, lands, and families: all things, even our very lives if need be.” ([“Obedience, Consecration, and Sacrifice,” Ensign](#), May 1975)

➡ 2. **Lectures on Faith:** “7. Let us here observe, that a religion that does not require the sacrifice of all things never has power sufficient to produce the faith necessary unto life and salvation.” (*Lectures on Faith*, Lecture Sixth)

➡ 3. **Elder Dallin H. Oaks:** “I love the musical and motion picture *Fiddler on the Roof*. There a wonderful Jewish father sings “If I Were a Rich Man.” His memorable prayer concludes with this pleading question:

Lord, who made the lion and the lamb,
You decreed I should be what I am;
Would it spoil some vast eternal plan,
If I were a wealthy man?
(Lyrics by Sheldon Harnick [1964])

“Yes, Tevye, it might. Let us give thanks for what we are and for the circumstances God has given us for our personal journey through mortality.” ([“Give Thanks in All Things,” Ensign](#), May 2003)

➡ 4. **President Joseph F. Smith:** “The rich man may enter into the kingdom of heaven as freely as the poor, if he will bring his heart and affections into subjection to the law of God and to the principle of truth; if he will place his affections upon God, his heart upon the truth, and his soul upon the accomplishment of God’s purposes and not fix his affections and his hopes upon the things of the world.” (*Gospel Doctrine*, 260-261)

➡ 5. **Elder Neal A. Maxwell:** “Jesus counseled us, too, concerning materialism and ‘the deceitfulness of riches’ (Matthew 13:22), and of how hard it is for those who trust in riches and materialism to enter into the kingdom of God. (See Luke 18:24.) ... Can those who are diverted by riches or the search for riches and thus fail to discern the real purposes of life be safely trusted with greater dominions which call for even greater discernment? ‘And he that overcometh, and keepeth my works unto the end, to him will I give power over the nations.’ (Revelation 2:26.)

([“Thanks Be to God,” Ensign](#), July 1982, 53)

➡ 6. **Elder James E. Talmage:** “The covenant people of Israel, were the specially invited guests... When all was ready, on the appointed day, they were generally summoned by the Messenger who had been sent by the Father; He was even then in their midst. But the cares of riches, the allurements of material things, and the pleasures of social and domestic life had engrossed them; and they prayed to be excused or irreverently declared that they could not or would not come...” (*Jesus the Christ*, Chapter 27, Parable of the Great Supper)

➡ 7. **President J. Reuben Clark:** “I come to see that the things which men give in the way of honor and respect and office and position are really of little worth. They are not worth what sometimes we feel we have to give in order to obtain them. I come to know that worldly goods are of no consequence whatever, save I have enough to eat, and to drink and reasonably to wear, and that to attempt to leave wealth to my children will not only be a futile effort but that it may prove a curse.

I do not mean by this that we should cease to exert our efforts to become influential for good in our communities. I do not mean that we should forget that we are living here and have our lives to live. I do not forget that a reasonable provision for those who come after us is a wise thing. I am only saying that none of these things is worth the sacrifice of a principle. They are not worth the sacrifice of our integrity, of our honor, of our righteous living. (Conference Report, October 1948, p. 78. Cited in Dallin H. Oaks, Chapter 5 [Materialism](#), *Pure in Heart*, Salt Lake City: Bookcraft, 1988, pp. 73-86)

➡ 8. **Elder James E. Talmage:** “Our Lord’s purpose was to show the contrast between the care, thoughtfulness, and devotion of men engaged in the money-making affairs of earth, and the half hearted ways of many who are professedly striving after spiritual riches. Worldly-minded men do not neglect provision for their future years, and often are sinfully eager to amass plenty; while the ‘children of light,’ or those who believe spiritual wealth to be above all earthly possessions are less energetic, prudent, or wise.” (*Jesus the Christ*, Chapter 27, Parable of the Unrighteous Steward)

➡ 9. **Elder James E. Talmage:** “Take a lesson from even the dishonest and the evil; if they are so prudent as to provide for the only future they think of, how much more should you, who believe in an eternal future, provide therefor... Emulate the unjust steward and the lovers of mammon, not in their dishonesty, cupidity, and miserly hoarding of the wealth that is at best but transitory, but in their zeal, forethought, and provision for the future. Moreover, let not wealth become your master; keep it to its place as a servant, for, ‘No servant can serve two masters: for either he will hate the one, and love the other; or else he will hold the one, and despise the other. Ye cannot serve God and mammon.’” (*Jesus the Christ*, Chapter 27, Parable of the Unrighteous Steward)

Losses Can Become Gains

“It pulled our family together and showed us what was really important in life,” Martin said. **Martin** lived just up the hill from us. “Up the hill” often has meaning beyond the geographical in our location; it often means up the economic ladder quite successfully. He was **a professional man in southern California with a thriving practice and a comfortable financial portfolio**, but he was also a conscientious father. He cared about his family and was concerned about the environment they were growing up in, so he moved them back to Utah to be among the Saints. He knew, as we do, that there is sin in the valleys of the mountains, just as there is everywhere else in the world. But he felt that living where there was a higher concentration of Mormons would be helpful.

To maintain the lifestyle to which he and his family had been accustomed, he still needed that income from his California clientele, so he commuted back and forth to work – flying to California for the week and returning home on weekends. This was a difficult arrangement, and he longed to be financially independent so he could stay home with his family in Utah. Finally, the opportunity came for him to put his life savings into an extremely high-yield investment. **Things were working out so well for him, it seemed too good to be true. It was. He lost everything.** He was forced to return with his family to California and essentially start over. They had to sell their beautiful homes, their fine cars, and their expensive country club memberships. [20-21]

After a while, they did save enough to go to Disneyland. Walking between the pirate ride and the Matterhorn with his happy children gathered close around him, Martin said, **“I would never have chosen to go through that, but it’s the best thing that ever happened to our family. It’s not where you live; it’s how you live and how much you love each other that matters. This experience has brought us together.”**

(Duane E. Hiatt, *Overcoming Personal Loss*, (Salt Lake City, Utah: Deseret Book Company, 1990) 20-21)

Other Study Sources:

[Commitment to the Gospel](#), James D. Gordon III, Ricks College Devotional, April 17, 2001
[Materialism](#), Elder Dallin H. Oaks, Chapter 5 in *Pure in Heart*, (Salt Lake City: Bookcraft, 1988), pp. 73-86